

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Problem-Solving and Data Analysis	Inference from sample statistics and margin of error	Easy

Question

At a large high school, 300 students were selected at random and were asked in a survey about a menu change in the school cafeteria. All 300 students completed the survey. It was estimated that 38% of the students were in support of a menu change, with a margin of error of 5.5%. Which of the following is the best interpretation of the survey results?

Answer

- A. The percent of the students at the school who support a menu change is 38%.
- B. The percent of the students at the school who support a menu change is greater than 38%.
- C. Plausible values of the percent of the students at the school who support a menu change are between 32.5% and 43.5%.
- D. Plausible values of the number of the students at the school who support a menu change are between 295 and 305.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is correct. It’s given that an estimated 38% of sampled students at the school were in support of a menu change, with a margin of error of 5.5%. It follows that the percent of the students at the school who support a menu change is 38% plus or minus 5.5%. The lower bound of this estimation is $38 - 5.5$, or 32.5%. The upper bound of this estimation is $38 + 5.5$, or 43.5%. Therefore, plausible values of the percent of the students at the school who support a menu change are between 32.5% and 43.5%.

Choice A is incorrect. This is the percent of the sampled students at the school who support a menu change. Choices B and D are incorrect and may result from misinterpreting the margin of error.